
UNIT 19 INTEGRATED MARKETING COMMUNICATION

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19.0 INTRODUCTION

In the previous units of this block, you have learnt in detail about advertising, public relations and event management. All of them along with many others are tools of marketing. This unit will expose you to the umbrella term – Integrated Marketing Communications (IMC) which makes use of various online and offline tools to achieve the marketing objective. While this unit will help you develop an insight into the strategic use of these tools, they will also give you a glimpse of how to establish strong business relationships with the audiences.

19.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After working through this unit, you will be able to:

- describe Integrated Marketing Communications, its need and tools.
- appreciate the benefits of integrated marketing efforts.

- Identify the important elements for making an integrated marketing plan; and
- Analyse the effects of social media revolution on IMC.

19.2 WHAT IS INTEGRATED MARKETING COMMUNICATIONS

Ever wondered what is the first point of contact of an organisation with the customer? As a customer when you want to consider a product for purchase, how do you first start seeking information about it? It is through a website. The purpose of a website is to help the customer. A website makes use of all the media components optimally to convey the message to the visitor in the best possible manner. So we find the use of text, visuals, audio as well as audio visual whenever needed while focusing on what needs to be conveyed in our communication through the site. The selection of media (text, audio, visuals and audio visuals) are done keeping in mind which medium can best make the point we as marketers want to stress upon. Similarly, integrated marketing communications makes use of different marketing tools optimally keeping in mind the target to achieve. We will discuss later in this unit that there are multiple marketing communication tools that we may use to achieve our objectives. Some of them are advertising, public relations and event management among others about which you have read in the previous units of this block.

Before proceeding with integrated marketing communications, let us look at some of the basic concepts:

Marketing: Marketing is a customer focused activity which involves the study and management of exchange relationships.

Communication: It is the sharing of experiences between two or more participants.

Marketing mix: The strategy formulated by an organisation on the basis of product, price, place and promotion to formulate its product or service for its customers is called marketing mix. In case of services, there are three additional factors to be considered while designing the offering – people, process and physical evidence. Let us understand this with the help of an example of a small car. So the product on offer is the small car, the price is what you expect the customer to pay in exchange of the car. The placement of the car pertains to the audience segment – in this case, the middle class customer and promotion is about the combination of tools used to communicate positively about the product to the audience.

As regards a service, there are three additional factors. Services, for example, food delivery service is intangible. So it is an additional challenge to make the customer feel satisfied with his experience. First of all, it is important to have physical evidence that the service was used. It adds some tangibility to an intangible offering. Then, the people offering the service, in this case, the food delivery person is the face of the company offering the service. The person's appearance, behavior, efficiency of task and pleasantries exchanged speak a lot about the service organisation. Also important is the process of providing the service – from the point of contact with the customer to the completion of delivery of service and receiving feedback. The entire process should be a pleasant one for the customer.

Communications mix: This is a tactical combination of communication tools used by the organisation keeping in mind the strategy devised to achieve the desired objectives. This includes the use of both online and offline for tools like advertising, public relations, sales promotion, sponsorship and others.

Now let us look at the definition of integrated marketing communications (IMC).

Simply put, integrated marketing communications involves the best use of resources to achieve best results by incurring minimum costs. It is a strategic management process which is economic, efficient and effective which makes use of marketing communications and is suited to any type of organisation.

Smith, Berry and Pulford have defined IMC in the following way:

“The strategic analysis, choice, implementation and control of all elements of marketing communications which efficiently, economically and effectively influence transactions between an organisation and its existing and potential customers, consumers and clients.”

IMC may also be defined as a strategic and well coordinated use of different promotional methods that reinforce each other to achieve the desired objectives for any organisation.

19.3 WHY MARKETING COMMUNICATIONS SHOULD BE INTEGRATED

It is important to integrate customer data, employees and marketing communications in order to maintain consistency of communication and ensure resource optimisation. As communication tools are multifarious, both online and offline, there may be multiple ways of more than one communications about the same product/service reaching the audience. Too much communication or communication from multiple sources may lead to confusion in the mind of the customer. Hence customer data need to be build and the communication with the customer needs to be monitored.

As for employees, it is important that they align with the values of the organisation they are working for. They are not only the face of their company; they are also the brand ambassadors and should believe in the values that their company stands for. This makes it important for the organisation to invest in its employees, keep them interested and motivated and also encourage their belief in their organisation's values.

19.4 WHAT ALL DO WE INTEGRATE

While marketing communications encompass all elements of communication that occur in the context of marketing, the tools of which we said we will discuss in the later part of this unit, ‘integrated’ as a word has been explained by the Smith et al in seven levels:

1. Integration of vertical objectives: The communication and marketing objectives should fit in with the overall organisational goals.
2. Horizontal integration: The marketing communications activities should fit in with other branches like manufacturing, operations and human resource management.

3. Integration of marketing mix: The marketing mix (explained above) needs to be integrated with the communication messages.
4. Integration of communication mix: The communication tools used should portray a consistent message to the customer.
5. Integration of creative design: There should be consistency between the creative design and positioning of the product/service.
6. Internal/External integration: There should be inter-departmental cohesion and they should also work consistently with the external agencies employed by the organisation.
7. Financial integration: The budgeting for various activities should be optimal ensuring effectiveness and efficiency while achieving the desired goals.

After learning about these levels of integration, you must be clear about the need of integrating the marketing and communication activities and how minutely it must be done in order to succeed in today's marketing environment. We shall now discuss the benefits of integrating the marketing communications.

19.5 TOOLS OF INTEGRATED MARKETING COMMUNICATIONS

19.5.1 Advertising

In simple terms, advertising means a public announcement, of availability of a product or services. But today advertising encompasses a paradigm of hinting, prodding, pushing and coaxing the consumers to make a purchase. From creating and identifying a need to convert it into a demand to enforce brand loyalty, advertising today is an umbrella term for all the messages that are aimed at a hard sell.

Usually a target group is identified loosely based on few parameters, based on age, gender, livelihood, location, family role or aspirations (demographics and psychographics). The media habits of this target group are then assessed to make reaching them easier and economical. Then messages for these media channels are formulated which inform, persuade and affect the target group and aims to convert them into customers.

Advertising can be defined by various features:

- 1) It is paid communication. Whether the money is spent on creating the message or buying media space, advertising involves huge budgets.
- 2) It is non personal. As the process involves mass media, there is no face to face interaction between the buyer and the seller.
- 3) Promotion of ideas. It not only tries to sell a product/service, it also tries to sell an idea.
- 4) Identified sponsor: The person or the company behind the ads is always known, even if not stated in the ad.
- 5) Influencing buyer's behaviour: from affecting the attitude by '*Daag acche hain*' to call upon a behaviour change by '*Just Swiggy it*', advertising tries to create a recall value.

- 6) Marketing Mix: out of the four elements: product, promotion price and place, advertising is a major portion of promotion.

The importance and relevance of advertising can be ascertained from the fact that this industry is currently the fifth largest in the world, after oil, automobiles, computers and electronics. And the fun fact is neither of these could also survive without advertising.

19.5.2 Public Relations

Public relations are management of many strategic relationships forged by the company. It could be with the buyers, stakeholders, media channels, employees, vendors or others. The process includes effective communication, mutual adjustment by all the parties and sharing values over commitments. Public Relations process cohesively manages the perceptions of the public about the brand, product or service. This could not possibly be achieved by one sided communication only. For creating a favorable image of the company, the complete communication process including feedback at several stages needs to be completed. Thus, as a process, Public Relations include

- Assessing and estimating the expectations from the company by the public and stakeholders
- Involving this view of the company to reflect in all the managerial as well as market decisions
- Researching about the courses of actions, their outcomes and effects on the company's image
- Planning and implementing the objectives in a manner to create a favorable image for the company.
- Troubleshooting and control in the times of crisis

Few tools in the armor of PR personnel are

- News releases – also called the press releases. Could be in textual, graphical or audio visual format. Contain news related to new product or services being launched by a brand. Are handed directly to media organisations to enable coverage.
- Media kit – Contains various types of promotional materials, again handed to media personnel during press conferences. It could also contain samples or coupon to try the product or services on offer so that a favorable opinion may be formed of the company.
- Social media – in today's times, social media prove to be a suitable platform for reaching out to the masses at a very fast pace and a comfortable rate. Posts on various social media platforms enable reach a vast audience segment informally.

19.5.3 Sponsorship

An emerging part of the integrated marketing communication, sponsorship is financial association of companies with other companies or events. Sponsorship not only helps in forging cross platform and cross media ties, it also helps in creating and reaffirming the brand image and values. You may remember asking to donate Rupee 1/- for any charitable organisation by including it in your shopping bill.

While it is not heavy on the consumer's pocket, it helps in associating a brand with charity and thus a 'good' image in public sphere.

Sponsorship entails fully or partially taking care of the economics of an event, cause or organisation. It can also include donations in cash or kind. For example, a sports drink may take care of the supply of drinks for the national cricket team, thus sponsoring in kind and in return getting a mention in press releases, branding in the stadium, ads on TV or all of these.

While sponsorship helps in brand building by association, brand placement by merchandise and visual displays, it may also help in diversifying the market. For example, Close Up has been a youth targeting toothpaste brand, which has ads showing young people getting comfortable with each other because of lack of mouth odor. But due to sponsoring the Close Up Antakshari on TV, close up diversified its target group from mere youngsters to the family audience.

Sponsorship for charity also helps in the company balance sheets as it helps in tax rebates as well. Cairn India is another example for smart sponsorship. While on one hand the company was showcased in poor light by the media for uprooting tribes from Rajasthan to set up their oil plants, they made up by sponsoring many NGO's working for the betterment of the same communities and their re-settlement.

19.5.4 Sales Promotion, Gamification and Content Marketing

Sales promotion is very simply put, an added advantage for the buyer (consumer / distributor / dealer) in the process of buying a product or service. The incentives are usually short term and are put in effect at the time of making a purchase decision. Here are some of the techniques employed during sales promotion:

- 1) **Communication:** the sales personnel inform, orients and persuades the buyer in order to make a sale. At times the customer buys the product or service due to the personalised attention and at times the new information provided makes the purchase inevitable.
- 2) **Incentivise:** The sales team offers further incentives or throws in freebies for the customer to lock in the purchase. At times few discount coupons are also handed out to motivate further purchase in future.
- 3) **Invitation:** Memberships with a promise of incentives in near future are also offered in order to garner loyalty from the customers.

Various tools and techniques utilised by the sales promotion team are:

- 1) **Letters and mails:** used as a personalised means of communication, the letters act as reminders or drivers for sales motivation for the customers.
- 2) **Point of purchase displays:** A variety of poster, streamers and banners among others are used to capture the attention of the customers and give out information. A lot of interactive design is also being utilised by many stores.
- 3) **Demonstrations:** A suitable example of increasing the human interaction. Demonstration could be a door to door sample testing of a detergent or even a test drive for a car. It makes a potential customer get the feel of using the product and see the results first hand. Sometimes media representative are called in for demonstrations so that their reports later reach a wider audience.

- 4) **Offers and discounts:** Various short terms discounts and various offers are introduced time to time to increase the sales. An exchange sale in an electronics shop or an offseason discount on winter clothing would be apt examples.
- 5) **Coupons and gifts:** First time customers may be offered few schemes and gifts for initiating a purchase. At times long time loyalists are also offered gifts to reward their long association.

Gamification in marketing has become a new approach to keep the consumers engaged and motivated. Gamification simply means integrating game mechanics into a sales process. It could be something as simple as collecting wrappers of a chewing gum to exchange later for another pack or getting reward points in a membership card after each purchase from a store, which can be redeemed later on. Gamification not only rewards the loyal customers, it also motivates them to return for future purchases as well.

Content marketing is the process of generating content in order to sell the products. Be it a travel blog on a travel agent's site or photos uploaded by amateur stylists on a clothing ecommerce app. With the help of digital media, creation of content has become much easier and with the help of social media, reaching out to a large number of people has become much faster for the brands. It is the content marketing which has made teenagers using Instagram the new age influencers.

19.5.5 Direct Mail and E-mail

Mailers are an extremely cost effective yet personal way of reaching out to a target group. It can be utilised for sending reminders or coupons for existing customers and easy samples and demonstration options to acquire a new customer base. One can also use it to inform the customers about new products or additions and thus build brand loyalty. Mailing lists with various target profiles are provided by many service providers. Bulk emails and mails are any day much cheaper than any other form of reaching out to the base.

Mailers can be designed in a manner that suits the target group thus making the communication more effective. While a generic ad has to reach out to a larger mass of people, mail is more personal and niche. With the help of coupons sent out, one can easily assess the profitability and the response ratio of the mailers.

In times before internet, regular mail was used to reach out to the target group. In today's time, email has very rapidly replaced the need for sending out mails through postal services. Here is a list of differences between regular mail and email –

Regular mail:

- Lesser in numbers
- Novelty in today's time
- Samples can be sent across
- Experience more real
- Response rate higher
- Can be lost

- Language barrier
- Slower

E – mail:

- Great numbers
- Creates spam
- Links to web pages can be sent across
- Experience more transient
- Response rate lesser
- Language and technological barrier
- Faster
- Can get lost in the bulk

Slowly with the expansion of Internet in our daily lives, mails could become intrusive and sharing email addresses has invoked various privacy issues. But still, one can unsubscribe to these mails to stay away from the persistent advertisers.

19.5.6 Events, Exhibitions and Conferences

Events of any kind are a great way to congregate and socialise. Be it some promotional event, press conference or display of products, events prove to be great tool to inform and persuade the target group. There are many types of events, ranging from charity and cultural to sports and corporate. Each serves a different purpose by catering to a different set of audience.

While planning an event, few of the factors are extremely important to analyse:

- What is the purpose of the event?

If it is a trade fair, the purpose is to meet potential customers and vendors. If it is a charity event, purpose is to create a favorable image for the company. From increasing sales to strengthening public relations, the purposes could be many.

- For whom is the event being organised?

A sports meet will be flocked by the youth, a book fair will be frequented by the people who would like to read and a painting exhibition will be visited by art aficionados.

- What is the plan of action?

What do you plan to do when the audience arrives at the venue? How are you going to keep their interest? What will be their takeaways? How do you propose to elongate their engagement?

- When and where of the event?

Now is the time to start planning the logistics. What time would be suitable for holding the event? A charity ball cannot be organised in the morning, similarly a bhajan sandhya cannot be organised post 8 PM. The venue also plays a very important role in the scheme of things. Adequate parking space,

accessibility and enough space for moving about are important considerations to make.

With the advent of technology, event management industry has also found ways to incorporate it. From bar code scanners to virtual meet ups, apps to register and social media to send reminders and registration details; there are a multiple number of ways how technology is aiding real world socialisation as well.

19.5.7 Merchandising and Point of Sale

Merchandising involves all the activities that boost and promote the sale of goods or services at retail. It includes a variety of activities including determination of packaging and display, creating display designs, developing communication strategies and promoting discounts and coupons. Retailers may or may not be the producers of the product. In this case, the merchandisers ensure that the product finds a favorable representation at the outlet in order to create sale.

Merchandising is never uniform. It may differ on the basis of place, time, occasion and competition. Lately it has started reflecting through various media platforms as well. With the help of social media and ecommerce, various merchandise promoting shows, films and characters can also be seen being sold. Different kinds of merchandising include:

- 1) Product merchandising – this includes aesthetic shelf displays and colour coordinated products in the case of physical spaces and artistically done product photography in case of e commerce
- 2) Retail merchandising – the activities that are done to make the retail space more enjoyable. It could include displays, demonstrations, streamers and banners.
- 3) Visual merchandising – it includes using elements of spacing, lighting and design to heighten the visual appeal of the product. In terms of e commerce, it could be UI and UX of and app.
- 4) Digital merchandising – it encompasses the activities taking place electronically. In today's time, digital is involved in sales all the way. From promotional material to paying by card. Digital merchandising works to incorporate digital interface seamlessly into the experience.

Point of sale is the marketing material which enables the customer in making the buying decision promptly. Ranging from shelf decorations to streamers, banners and other paraphernalia in the store, POS solidify the brand image in a consumer's head. Working as a silent salesperson, these displays are non-intrusive and decorative.

19.5.8 Packaging

It is often said that a person is a complete package. What is meant by the statement is that he/she comes as a complete solution to a problem. They are not dependent on any external parties in any manner, for finishing a given task. In terms of a product, packaging primarily means the process of designing and producing the wrapping for a product. It can also mean adding related freebies along with the product that will aide its usage. For e.g. A packet of detergent along with a washing machine will complete the package.

Packages are usually made after identifying the brand image, and the needs of the consumer in order to come up with feasible solutions. *Haldiram's* outlet at the airport packages its products in leakproof and pressure proof packaging in order to make them survive the flights that their buyers will take after purchasing them.

A package needs to be:

- Compact
- Lightweight
- Easy to carry
- Attractive
- Designed in adherence to the brand image
- Wear and tear proof

Packaging at times helps in making or breaking the decision at the time of purchase. Studies have shown that in case of two products of different brands, in same price range are available to the customer, the packaging plays an important role in making him/her decide what to buy.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. Delineate the concept of integrated marketing communications?

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2. What are the seven levels of integration in the context of marketing communication?

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3. Identify the major tools of integrated marketing communications?

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19.6 BENEFITS OF INTEGRATING THE MARKETING COMMUNICATION EFFORT

There are several benefits of IMC. Some of them are as follows:

1. It brings consistency to the communication made with the audience.
2. A consistent and clear communication does not confuse the audience.
3. Clear, consistent range of messages brings credibility to communication.
4. Integrating marketing communication efforts optimizes the use of resources and avoids wastage and duplication.
5. As customers become more aware through clear, consistent communication, there is a greater chance of making a positive purchase decision.
6. It helps in consolidating the image of an organisation.
7. It helps in building a dialogue with the customer which leads to building a relationship.
8. In the longer run, it also ensures brand loyalty.
9. Since IMC is more effective, it increases profit for the organisation.
10. It creates a competitive advantage for the organisation and a holistic, positive experience for the customer.

With these benefits of IMC in mind, let us now learn how to plan an integrated marketing communications campaign.

19.7 MAKING AN INTEGRATED MARKETING PLAN

There is no fixed approach for making a marketing and/or marketing and communications plan. But there are always some essential elements which must be a part of the plan to ensure its success. One widely used approach is SOSTAC plan which cover these key components. The elements of SOSTAC are as follows:

S-Situation: This includes the situation analysis to answer the question – ‘where are we now?’ A study of the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats (SWOT) helps in ascertaining the need and pace of performance in order to achieve the objectives.

O- Objectives: These are the long term and short term objectives that marketing communications would focus on. These are the measurable objectives that an organisation is set to achieve in a given time like building sales volume, increase in share prices, increasing awareness among the customers and positioning a product. It answers the question – ‘where are we going?’

S-Strategy: In order to achieve the set objectives, certain marketing mix and communication mix will have to be decided keeping in mind the target to be achieved, the budget and the time available. It answers the question – ‘how do we get there?’

T-Tactics: The tactics spells the details of the strategy to be used, the marketing communications mix. Tactics entails the decision on the tools of communication to be used and in what sequence and how much would be spent on the activity. It answers the question – ‘what is the detail of the strategy?’

A-Action: This decides the actual plan of action required so that all the activities fall in line as per the plan. It includes the background work to be done and internal activities to take place for creating the tools to deliver the strategy. It answers the question – ‘what steps are required to put each tool in action?’

C-Control: It is important to introduce some checks and balances in a marketing communications activity to ensure that the activity is on the right track. There must be some scope for measuring the results and introducing mid-term corrections if needed. Control helps one to know whether the targets are being met and how can outcome be maximised. It answers the question – ‘are we getting there or not?’

In addition to the SOSTAC, there are also 3 Ms that were added to this marketing plan. The 3 Ms are explained below:

M-Men and women: This M talks about the human resource that is involved in the plan, their capacity, capability and expertise.

M-Money: Money comprises the budget estimates and cash availability to carry out the marketing communications activity.

M-Minutes: Minutes are the timelines that are set to complete the task as a whole and in small chunks. The bigger tasks are divided into smaller chunks and time schedules are maintained to ensure that the whole task is completed on time.

19.8 EFFECT OF SOCIAL MEDIA REVOLUTION ON IMC

The advent of social media has taken the marketing world by storm. While the marketers have a new set of tools to reach out to the audience, it has also made it important to know and understand the audiences’ habits, perceptions and tastes in order to create a positive influence on them. Over the last decade, a number of innovative techniques have made their way into marketing communications which has taken marketing to the next level. A few are discussed here:

- **Marketing Automation:** Marketing strategies have been automated to provide tailored information which is more relevant and personalised to the customer at the right time and platform when she is best ready to receive it.
- **Social CRM (Customer Relationship Management):** Social media have made it easier for organisations to engage their audiences in a cost effective and impactful communication. With CRM going social, it has become simpler to keep the audience positively engaged which creates greater chances of converting a lead into a customer.
- **Big Data:** Big data refers to unstructured, huge volumes of data collected from different sources. The data is usually deciphered by reading digital imprints and channels like mobile, internet and social media. Buying huge data sets of customers indicating their choices, needs, preferences, budget, habits, social status, values and beliefs helps the marketers to push a particular

product or service effectively. Big data analysis has made it possible for the marketer to know the moment the customer enters a store what that person is looking for, what is one's taste and one's budget to purchase a commodity. It also helps in remarketing a product and retargeting a prospective customer.

- **Analytics:** Data analytics is more focused than big data. It sifts through huge piles of big data to get answers to specific questions relevant to businesses. While big data employs complex technical tools, data analytics makes use of statistical modeling and other simpler tools. Analysis of data helps in getting valuable business insights, spotting patterns to make recommendations and study trends over time.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. List the benefits of integrated marketing communications?

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2. What are the dominant elements of an integrated marketing plan?

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19.9 LET US SUM UP

In this unit you have learnt what is integrated marketing communications, why should marketing communications be integrated and what all do we integrate to get a holistic output of the marketing activities. The unit also explained the tools of marketing communications like public relations, sales promotions, packaging and sponsorships. You have also learnt how to make an IMC plan and effects of social media revolution on it. It gave you an idea about the importance of marketing communications in today's world, how technology has impacted marketing communications and how marketing environment will change due to fast changing marketing communications innovations, a lot of which comes from technology.

19.10 KEYWORDS

Advertising	: Non-personal but paid message for the target audience.
Content marketing	: Process of generating content to sell the products in the market.
Gamification	: Keeping the consumers engaged and motivated in a sales process.
Marketing mix	: Contains product, promotion, price and place.
Merchandise	: Product displayed by retailers.
Public relations	: Management of strategic relationship forged by the company.

Sponsorship : Financial association with commercial and other organisations for conducting events.

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19.12 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. The idea of integrated marking communication is to bring and organization and then customer of its products and/or services together by providing the necessary information. It uses different channels of communication from websites to social media to communicate the messages in the form of text, graphics, and video, audio and audio-visual. The integrated marketing communications also employ many types of marketing strategies for realization of their goals.
2. The seven levels of integration suggested by Smith et al are ; integration of vertical objectives horizontal objectives, marketing mix, communication mix, creative design, internal and external elements, and financial.
3. The major tools of integrated marketing communication are : advertising, public relations sponsorship, sales promotion, gamification, content marketing, direct mail, e-mail, events, exhibitions and conferences, beside merchandising, point of sale and packaging.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Some of the important benefits of integrated marketing communication are : consistency of communication with customers, clarity and credibility of messages, optimization of resources, positive purchase decisions, building relationship with customers, and brand loyalty, increase in profit and comparative advantage for the organization.
2. Situation, objectives (both short and long term), strategies of marketing mix and communication mix, budget, activities as per plan, control means use of checks and balances, efficient use of human resources and money, maintaining timelines in addition to effective use of social media and data analysis.

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- Select a company with which you are familiar. Describe the company's corporate communication in terms of its corporate identity, image and reputation.

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- Write a press release for the launch of Honda's first diesel car 'Amaze'. Refer to course material on how to write a press release and also prepare a power point presentation.
- Develop a PR programme for an organisation of your choice (organisation may be of government owned or public welfare) it should cover development of public relations objective, communication programme, content / message development, media co-ordination and impact / result monitoring.

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